CHAPTER 9

Argumentative Essays

Mani stones, Nepal

An **argumentative essay** is an essay in which you agree or disagree with an issue, using reasons to support your opinion. Your goal is to convince your reader that your opinion is right. Argumentation is a popular kind of essay question because it forces students to think on their own: They have to take a stand on an issue, support their stand with solid reasons, and support their reasons with solid evidence.

In a general writing test such as the TOEFL exam, you might encounter questions such as these:

> The U.S. Declaration of Independence states that "all men are created equal." Agree or disagree with this statement. Support your opinion with reasons and examples.

> The most important element in a friendship is trust. Agree or disagree with this statement. Support your opinion with reasons and examples.

In an academic class, your instructor might ask questions such as these:

CRIMINAL JUSTICE — Some cities in the United States and the United Kingdom have passed laws establishing curfews for young people. Young people (usually age 17 and younger) may not be out on the streets after 9 or 10 P.M. Do you agree or disagree with such curfews?

HEALTH SCIENCES — Stem cell research offers a potential cure for many fatal diseases. Many people oppose stem cell research because it involves using cells from human embryos. Do you agree or disagree that stem cell research should be prohibited?

BUSINESS ETHICS — Companies that do business abroad sometimes find that local business practices include activities considered unethical at home—offering gifts of money or awarding contracts to family members, for example. Should companies go along with local business practices in order to become successful, or should they refuse to do so and risk failure as a result?

What is unique about an argumentative essay is that you do not just give reasons to support your point of view. You must also discuss the other side's reasons and then rebut them. (*Rebut* means to point out problems with the other side's reasons to prove that they are not good reasons.) We do this because we want readers to know that we have considered all sides of the issue. When we show that we are reasonable and open-minded, readers are more likely to listen to our point of view.

Organization of Argumentative Essays

There are several ways to organize an argumentative essay. You can use a block pattern or a point-by-point pattern. The outlines in the following chart show these two possible patterns.

Block Pattern	Point-by-Point Pattern
I. Introduction Explanation of the issue Thesis statement	**I.** Introduction Explanation of the issue, including a summary of the other side's arguments Thesis statement
II. Body **Block 1** **A.** Summary of other side's arguments **B.** Rebuttal to the first argument **C.** Rebuttal to the second argument **D.** Rebuttal to the third argument **Block 2** **E.** Your first argument **F.** Your second argument **G.** Your third argument	**II.** Body **A.** Statement of the other side's first argument and rebuttal with your own counterargument **B.** Statement of the other side's second argument and rebuttal with your own counterargument **C.** Statement of the other side's third argument and rebuttal with your own counterargument
III. Conclusion—may include a summary of your point of view	**III.** Conclusion—may include a summary of your point of view

There are many variations on these two patterns. Which pattern you use will depend on your topic. With some topics, one pattern works better than others. The important thing is to present your side and rebut the other side in a logical and organized way.

As you read the following model essay, study its organization.

MODEL
Argumentation

Separating the Sexes, Just for the Tough Years

1 The middle school years (grades 7 and 8) are known to be the "tough years." These are the years when the uneven pace of girls' and boys' physical, emotional, and cognitive development is most noticeable. Girls are ahead of boys on all counts, and both suffer. Educators debate whether separating boys and girls during these difficult years might improve students' academic performance. Separate classes are now prohibited in public schools that receive federal funds, but a change in the federal law that prohibits them is under consideration. Although some parents and educators oppose same-sex classes, there is some evidence that separating boys and girls in middle school yields positive results.

2 Opponents of single-sex education claim that test scores of students in all-girl or all-boy classes are no higher than those of students in mixed classes ("Study").[1] However, the research is inconclusive. Despite the fact that some research shows no improvement in test scores, other research shows exactly opposite results (Blum).[2] More important, many psychologists believe that test scores are the wrong measuring sticks. They believe that self-confidence and self-esteem issues are more important than test scores. In same-sex classes, girls report increased confidence and improved attitudes toward math and science, for example ("Study"). These are results that cannot be calculated by a test but that will help adolescents become successful adults long after the difficult years of middle school are past. New York University professor Carol Gilligan is certain that girls are more likely to be "creative thinkers and risk-takers as adults if educated apart from boys in middle school" (Gross).[3] Boys, too, gain confidence when they do not have to compete with girls. Boys at this age become angry and fight back in middle school because they feel inferior when compared to girls, who literally "out-think" them. With no girls in the classroom, they are more at ease with themselves and more receptive to learning (Gross).

3 Opponents also maintain that separate classes (or separate schools) send the message that males and females cannot work together. They say that when students go into the work force, they will have to work side-by-side with the opposite sex, and attending all-girl or all-boy schools denies them the opportunity to learn how to do so ("North").[4] However, such an argument completely ignores the fact that children constantly interact with members of the

[1]"Study: All-Girls Schools Don't Improve Test Scores." CNNinteractive 12 Mar. 1998. 2 June 2004 <http://www.cnn.com/US/9803/same.sex.classes/>.
[2]Blum, Justin. "Scores Soar at D.C. School with Same-Sex Classes." washingtonpost.com 27 June 2002. 2 June 2004 <http://www.washingtonpost.com/ac2/wp-dyn/A52023–2002Jun26?/language=printer>.
[3]Gross, Jane. "Splitting Up Boys and Girls, Just for the Tough Years." The New York Times 31 May 2004: A16.
[4]"North Carolina School Stops Same-Sex Classes." American Civil Liberties Union News 5 Apr. 2000. 2 June 2004 <http://archive.aclu.org/news/2000/w040500d.html>.

opposite sex outside school. From playing and squabbling with siblings to negotiating allowances, chores, and privileges with their opposite-sex parent, children learn and practice on a daily basis the skills they will need in their future workplaces.

4 The final argument advanced by opponents of same-sex education is that it is discriminatory and, therefore, unconstitutional. However, research supports exactly the opposite conclusion: that discrimination is widespread in mixed classes. Several studies have shown that boys dominate discussions and receive more attention than girls and that teachers call on boys more often than they call on girls, even when girls raise their hands ("North"). Clearly, this is discriminatory.

5 It should be evident that the arguments against same-sex classes are not valid. On the contrary, many people involved in middle-school education say that same-sex classes provide a better learning environment. Boys and girls pay less attention to each other and more attention to their schoolwork (Marquez).[5] As one teacher noted, "Girls are more relaxed and ask more questions; boys are less disruptive and more focused" ("North"). Girls are less fearful of making mistakes and asking questions in math and science; boys are less inhibited about sharing their ideas in language and literature. Furthermore, schoolchildren are not disadvantaged by lack of contact with the opposite sex because they have many opportunities outside the school setting to interact with one another. Finally, discrimination occurs in mixed classes, so discrimination is not a valid argument. Therefore, in my opinion, the law prohibiting same-sex classes in public schools should be changed.

Writing Technique Questions

1. In which paragraph does the writer give background information to help readers understand the issue?
2. Does the thesis statement mention both sides of the issue, or does it give the writer's point of view only?
3. How many opposing arguments are given? Where are they given?
4. Where does the writer rebut the opposing arguments—in one paragraph or in separate paragraphs?
5. What is the function of the last paragraph?
6. Which type of organization does this essay use—block or point-by-point?

[5]Marquez, Laura. "No Distractions? Proposed Title IX Changes Would Allow Separate Classrooms for Girls and Boys." ABC News 13 May 2004. 2 June 2004 <http://abcnews.go.com/sections/WNT/US/same_sex_classrooms_040513.html>.

PRACTICE 1
Outlining

Complete the outline of the model essay.

Separating the Sexes, Just for the Tough Years

I. Introduction (explanation of the issue)
Thesis statement: _____
_____

II. Body
A. Opposing argument 1
Opponents of single-sex education claim that test scores show that there is no advantage to all-girl or all-boy classes.
Rebuttal to argument 1
1. Research is inconclusive—show opposite results
2. Other results that cannot be calculated
a. Girls _____
b. Boys _____

B. Opposing argument 2
_____
Rebuttal to argument 2
_____
a. Settling squabbles with siblings
b. Negotiating with opposite-sex parent

C. Opposing argument 3
_____
Rebuttal to argument 3
_____
a. _____
b. Teachers call on boys more often

D. Own point of view
1. Same-sex classes provide a better learning environment
2. Reasons
a. Boys and girls _____
b. Girls _____
c. Boys _____

III. Conclusion

Five Keys

An argumentative essay contains these five key elements:

1. An explanation of the issue
2. A clear thesis statement
3. A summary of the opposing arguments
4. Rebuttals to the opposing arguments
5. Your own arguments

The Introductory Paragraph

The introductory paragraph of the model contains an explanation of the issue, which is a necessary part of an argumentative essay. However, you may also begin an argumentative essay with a more engaging introduction—with surprising statistics, for example, or with a dramatic story. For instance, the writer of the model essay could have opened with a dramatization of typical boys' and girls' behavior in a mixed middle school class.

If you write an attention-getting introduction, you may need to explain the issue in a second introductory paragraph and write your thesis statement at the end of this (the second) paragraph.

> In an eighth-grade English class at Kent Middle School, the students are discussing *The Diary of Anne Frank*, written by a 13-year-old Jewish girl while she hid with her family in an Amsterdam attic for more than two years during the Holocaust. The girls in the class identify easily with Anne and freely share their feelings about the book. The boys, by contrast, snicker[1] or snooze[2]—anything to avoid revealing any tender feelings. In the next class, math, the dynamic is reversed: The girls sit quietly, while the boys shout out answers and race each other to the blackboard to solve algebra equations. These scenes are typical in most middle school classes in the United States.
>
> The middle school years (grades 7 and 8) are known . . .

Thesis Statement

The thesis statement in an argumentative essay states clearly which side you are for:

> Curfew laws are unfair and should be abolished.
>
> In my opinion, stem cell research should receive the full support of our government.

A thesis statement often mentions the opposing point of view. Notice that the writer's opinion is expressed in the main (independent) clause, and the opposing point of view is normally put into a subordinate structure.

> SUBORDINATE STRUCTURE
> Despite the claims that curfew laws are necessary to control juvenile gangs,
> MAIN (INDEPENDENT) CLAUSE
> **curfew laws are clearly unconstitutional.**

> SUBORDINATE STRUCTURE
> Although there are certainly reasons to be cautious with stem cell research
> MAIN (INDEPENDENT) CLAUSE
> or any new technology, **I believe that its potential benefits far outweigh its dangers.**

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[1]**snicker:** laugh quietly in a way that is not nice
[2]**snooze:** sleep

Use expressions such as the following to introduce opposing points of view.

Some people feel that the United States should have a national health care plan like Canada's.

Many think that genetically engineered crops are a grave danger to the environment.

Smokers say that they have a right to smoke.

It may be true that the U.S. Constitution gives citizens the right to own weapons.

Then connect the opposing point of view to your own with transition signals of contrast.

Some people feel that the United States should have a national health care plan like Canada's**; however,** others feel that government should stay out of the health care business.

Although/Even though many think that genetically engineered crops are a grave danger to the environment, such crops can alleviate world hunger and malnutrition.

Smokers say that they have a right to smoke **in spite of the fact that/despite the fact that** smoking will kill them.

While/Whereas it may be true that the U.S. Constitution gives citizens the right to own weapons, the men who wrote the Constitution lived in a different time.

PRACTICE 2
Thesis Statements

Add an opposing point of view to each of the following thesis statements. If necessary, rewrite the part of the sentence that is given to you. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. Doctors or family members should never be allowed to "pull the plug."[1]
   Although some people believe that doctors and family members should never be allowed to "pull the plug," I believe that it is sometimes more humane to do so.
2. The sale of CDs with songs containing lyrics that degrade women should be prohibited.
   _____
   _____
3. Television is the worst invention of modern times.
   _____
   _____
4. Environmental protection laws go too far.
   _____
   _____

[1]**pull the plug:** let a person who is in an irreversible coma die by disconnecting him or her from life-sustaining machines

5. The advertising industry performs many public services.

_____

_____

6. Choose your own topic. Then write a thesis statement that expresses both sides of the issue.

_____

_____

PRACTICE 3
Supporting Arguments

Think of two or three supporting arguments for each thesis statement. Notice that two of the thesis statements state only the writer's point of view, and two state both sides of the argument. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. Censorship of the arts is always wrong.
   a. Freedom to express oneself is a fundamental right stated in the U.S. Bill of Rights.
   b. Public morality is relative—what is objectionable in some cultures is acceptable in others.
   c. Many masterpieces—books, sculptures, and paintings—would be banned.
2. Violence in video games, movies, and television programs should be censored.
   a. _____
   b. _____
   c. _____
3. Despite the fact that education's primary responsibility is to train minds, not bodies, I believe that schools should require students to practice a sport at least one hour each day.
   a. _____
   b. _____
   c. _____
4. Although some people think that curfew laws will help control teenage gangs, they are wrong for several reasons.
   a. _____
   b. _____
   c. _____
5. Engaged couples should be required to take marriage preparation classes for one full year before their wedding.
   a. _____
   b. _____
   c. _____
6. Your own topic: _____
   a. _____
   b. _____
   c. _____

Review

These are the important points covered in this chapter.

1. An argumentative essay is a kind of essay in which you try to persuade your reader to agree with your opinion about a controversial topic.
2. An argumentative essay contains these five elements:
   - An explanation of the issue
   - A clear thesis statement
   - A summary of the opposing arguments
   - Rebuttals to the opposing arguments
   - Your own arguments
3. Use either a block pattern or a point-by-point pattern. Be sure to include the opposite point of view as well as your own.
4. Use contrast transition signals to connect opposing arguments and your counter-arguments.

Writing Practice

Choose topic 1 or 2 and write an argumentative essay.

1. Agree or disagree with the following statement:
   It is worth the expense and risk to make a manned flight to Mars.
2. Agree or disagree with the following statement:
   The future status of English as the global language is assured.

Writing an argumentative essay requires especially careful planning.

Step 1 Clarify in your mind what the two sides of the argument are. Decide which side you agree with.

Step 2 Write a thesis statement. Your thesis statement can state either just your point of view or both points of view.

Step 3 Research the topic to get ideas and supporting reasons for both sides of the argument. The readings for this chapter on pages 151–152 and 154–155 provide material for your essay. Read the articles and do the exercises for your topic before you begin this writing assignment. You should use quotations, summaries, or paraphrases from the appropriate parts of the readings to support your arguments. You may also use material from Practices 1, 2, and 5 in Chapter 8 in your essay.

Step 4 Decide whether you will use block or point-by-point organization. Then develop an outline similar to one of the outlines on page 143.

Step 5 Write your first draft. Write an explanatory or an attention-getting introduction, as you prefer.

Step 6 Use the Self-Editing Worksheet on page 329 and revise your essay if necessary.

Step 7 Exchange papers with a classmate. Review each other's essays and complete the Peer-Editing Worksheet on page 330.

Step 8 Make changes if necessary and write a final copy to hand in to your instructor. Your instructor may ask you to hand in your outline, drafts, and editing worksheets along with your final copy.

Step 9 If your instructor asks you to use formal documentation of your sources, prepare a Works Cited list. Learn how in Appendix E, pages 308–311.

Applying What You Have Learned

Argumentative Essays

Topic 1

It is/is not worth the expense and risk to make a manned flight to Mars.

Reading 1

This reading presents several arguments in favor of sending a manned flight to Mars.

Why We Should Send a Manned Mission to Mars[1]

1 Mars has fascinated Earth-bound humans since prehistoric times, due to its captivating red hue and proximity and similarity to Earth. The romance of space travel and the exploration of new worlds is a major argument in favor of a manned mission to Mars. Supporters claim that exploring and colonizing the moon and Mars will give us a better understanding of our own home planet, Earth. Other supporters are motivated by feelings of national pride, saying the prestige of the United States is at stake. Still others believe that the research required by such a complex mission will help the United States retain its position as a leader in science and technology.

2 The success of the Apollo program in the 1960s and 1970s created a generation of astronaut heroes that inspired the nation. "In 1969, America sent men to the moon, not machines," Ben Wattenberg said on PBS's *Think Tank*. "[H]uman beings are exploratory creatures . . . mankind needs big ideas and big projects to ennoble and inspire society. Don't our little boys and girls need heroes and heroines to say, 'Look at him, look at her, she's there'?" President George W. Bush once said in an address to the nation, "Mankind is drawn to the heavens for the same reason we were once drawn to unknown lands and across the open sea. We choose to explore space because doing so improves our lives and lifts our national spirit."

3 Many supporters of manned travel to Mars argue that because of its similarity to Earth, Mars offers opportunities to discover the origins of life and ways to protect the environment on Earth.

4 "We cling to the hope of a neighboring planet that harbors . . . at least some primitive forms of life. If Mars contains even nanobacteria—or indisputable evidence of past life of the simplest forms—this will profoundly change our conception of our place in the universe," wrote Thomas Gangale. "If Mars is dead now, but was once alive, understanding how Mars died may give us a crucial understanding of how close we are coming to killing the Earth."

[1]Adapted from Joulwan, Melissa. "You Decide: Manned Mission to Mars." 13 May 2004 KQED 13 May 2004. 10 June 2004 <http://www.kqed.org/topics/news/perspectives/youdecide/pop/mars/index.jsp?flash=true>.

5 The Mars Society [a group that supports Mars exploration] shares that opinion. In its Founding Declaration, the society wrote, "As we begin the twenty-first century, we have evidence that we are changing the Earth's atmosphere and environment in significant ways. . . . Mars, the planet most like Earth, will have even more to teach us about our home world. The knowledge we gain could be key to our survival."

6 And many scientists assert that the best way to attain that knowledge is with human scientists. "Robots can do a lot," Chris Welch, a lecturer in space technology at Kingston University, told the BBC. "But having multiple trained human beings there would tell us so much more." Dava Newman, associate professor of aeronautics at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, agreed. "It's risky and it's also very costly, but there's just so much humans can do as explorers that we don't have any other way to accomplish."

7 China, Russia, and the European Union have all announced plans to boost their space programs in coming years, including sojourns to the moon and Mars. Some people believe it's essential to U.S. international status that the United States lead the way in space exploration. "Republican officials said conservative lawmakers who might balk at the cost [of a manned mission to Mars] are likely to be lured by the chance to extend the U.S. military supremacy in space when China is pursuing lunar probes and Russia is considering a Mars mission," Mike Allen and Eric Pianin wrote in *The Washington Post*.

8 The European Space Agency (ESA) has developed a long-term plan—known as Aurora—that will use robotics to first explore low-Earth orbit and then move farther out into planetary excursions, including Mars. The ESA intends to send a rover to Mars by 2009 and a manned mission to the moon by 2024 that will "demonstrate key life support and habitation technologies as well as aspects of crew performance and adaptation." The final step in the Aurora program is a human mission to Mars in the 2030s.

9 Regaining the top position in science and technology is another reason to support a Mars mission. According to *The New York Times*, the dominance the United States once had in science and innovation has declined in recent years as the number of international prizes and journal publications awarded to European and Asian researchers has increased. Jennifer Bond, vice president for international affairs for the Council on Competitiveness said, "Many other countries have realized that science and technology are key to economic growth and prosperity. They're catching up to us." She warned that people in the United States should not "rest on their laurels." A poll by the Associated Press seems to indicate that many people in the United States agree with her. Seventy-two percent of respondents in the poll deemed it important for the United States to be the "leading country in the world in the exploration of space."

10 "America is not going to remain at peace, and we're not going to remain the most prosperous nation, and we're not going to remain a free nation unless we remain the technological leader of the world," said Representative Dana Rohrabacher, chairman of the House Subcommittee on Space and Aeronautics. "And we will not remain the technological leader of the world unless we are the leaders in space."

Questions

1. Paragraph 1 summarizes four reasons why the United States should send a manned mission to Mars. List them here.
   a. _____
   b. _____
   c. _____
   d. _____

2. Which paragraph discusses the first reason? _____
   In your opinion, which sentence in the paragraph expresses this reason most clearly and concisely? Copy the sentence here. _____
   _____

3. Which paragraph(s) discuss(es) the second reason? _____
   Summarize the reason here. _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

4. Which paragraph(s) discuss(es) the third reason? _____
   Summarize the reason here. _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

5. Which paragraph(s) discuss(es) the fourth reason? _____
   Summarize the reason here. _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

Reading 2

This article from a popular weekly news magazine argues against sending a manned spacecraft to explore Mars.

Why We Shouldn't Go to Mars: Someday people may walk on the planet, but not until it makes technological sense[1]

1 "Two centuries ago, Meriwether Lewis and William Clark left St. Louis to explore the new lands acquired in the Louisiana Purchase," George W. Bush said, announcing his desire for a program to send men and women to Mars.[2] "They made that journey in the spirit of discovery. . . . America has ventured forth into space for the same reasons."

2 Yet there are vital differences between Lewis and Clark's expedition and a Mars mission. First, Lewis and Clark were headed to a place amenable to life; hundreds of thousands of people were already living there. Second, Lewis and Clark were certain to discover places and things of immediate value to the new nation. Third, the Lewis and Clark venture cost next to nothing by today's standards. In 1989 NASA estimated that a people-to-Mars program would cost $400 billion, which inflates to $600 billion today. The Hoover Dam cost $700 million in today's money, meaning that sending people to Mars might cost as much as building about 800 new Hoover Dams. A Mars mission may be the single most expensive non-wartime undertaking in U.S. history.

3 The thought of travel to Mars is exhilarating. Surely men and women will someday walk upon that planet, and surely they will make wondrous discoveries about geology and the history of the solar system, perhaps even about the very origin of life. Many times I have stared up at Mars in the evening sky—in the mountains, away from cities, you can almost see the red tint—and wondered what is there or was there.

4 But the fact that a destination is tantalizing does not mean the journey makes sense, even considering the human calling to explore. And Mars as a destination for people makes absolutely no sense with current technology.

5 Present systems for getting from Earth's surface to low-Earth orbit are so fantastically expensive that merely launching the 1,000 tons or so of spacecraft and equipment a Mars mission would require could be accomplished only by cutting health-care benefits, education spending, or other important programs—or by raising taxes. Absent some remarkable discovery, astronauts, geologists, and biologists once on Mars could do little more than analyze rocks and feel awestruck beholding the sky of another world. Yet rocks can be analyzed by automated probes without risk to human life, and at a tiny fraction of the cost of sending people.

6 It is interesting to note that when President Bush unveiled his proposal, he listed these recent major achievements of space exploration: pictures of the rings of Saturn and the outer planets, evidence of water on Mars and the moons of Jupiter, discovery of more than 100 planets outside our solar system, and study of the soil of Mars. All these accomplishments came from automated probes or

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[1]Easterbrook, Greg. "Why We Shouldn't Go to Mars: Someday people may walk on the planet, but not until it makes technological sense." Time 26 Jan. 2004: 51.

[2]The Louisiana Purchase was a very large area of land that was bought by the United States from France in 1803. Two men, Lewis and Clark, spent more than two years exploring and mapping the area.

automated space telescopes. Bush's proposal, which calls for "reprogramming" some of NASA's present budget into the Mars effort, might actually lead to a reduction in such unmanned science—the one aspect of space exploration that's working really well.

7 Rather than spend hundreds of billions of dollars to hurl tons toward Mars using current technology, why not take a decade—or two decades, or however much time is required—researching new launch systems and advanced propulsion? If new launch systems could put weight into orbit affordably, and if advanced propulsion could speed up that long, slow transit to Mars, then the dream of stepping onto the red planet might become reality. Mars will still be there when the technology is ready.

8 Space exploration proponents deride as lack of vision the mention of technical barriers or the insistence that needs on Earth come first. Not so. The former is rationality, the latter the setting of priorities. If Mars proponents want to raise $600 billion privately and stage their own expedition, more power to them; many of the great expeditions of the past were privately mounted. If Mars proponents expect taxpayers to foot their bill, then they must make their case against the many other competing needs for money. And against the needs for health care, education, poverty reduction, reinforcement of the military, and reduction of the federal deficit, the case for vast expenditures to go to Mars using current technology is very weak.

9 The drive to explore is part of what makes us human, and exploration of the past has led to unexpected glories. Dreams must be tempered by realism, however. For the moment, going to Mars is hopelessly unrealistic.

Questions

1. Most of paragraph 1 is a quotation by George W. Bush. Rewrite the direct quotation as an indirect quotation. Be sure to include a reporting phrase.

   _____

   _____

   _____

2. Paragraph 2 begins with a transition signal that signals contrast.
   a. What two things are contrasted? _____ and _____
   b. On what three points are they contrasted?
      (1) _____
      (2) _____
      (3) _____

3. Paragraph 4 contains the thesis statement for the essay. Copy it here. _____

   _____

   _____

4. Paragraphs 5, 6, 7, and 8 mention several reasons for not sending a manned spacecraft to Mars. Summarize the reasons here. _____

5. What kind of conclusion does this essay have?
   a. It summarizes arguments against a manned Mars mission.
   b. It paraphrases the thesis statement.

Topic 2

The future status of English as the global language is/is not assured.

Reading 1

This article, from a British weekly news magazine, discusses the reasons that English has become the dominant language around the world.

The World Language[1]

1 India has about a billion people and a dozen major languages of its own. One language, and only one, is understood—by an elite—across the country: that of the foreigners who ruled it for less than 200 years and left 52 years ago. After 1947, English had to share its official status with north India's Hindi and was due to lose it in 1965. It did not happen: Southern India said no.

2 Today, India. Tomorrow, unofficially, the world. [The spread of English] is well under way; at first, because the British not only built a global empire but settled America, and now because the world (and notably America) has acquired its first truly global—and interactive—medium, the Internet.

3 David Crystal, a British expert, estimates that some 350 million people speak English as their first language. Maybe 250–350 million do or can use it as a second language; in ex-colonial countries, notably, or in English-majority ones, like 30 million recent immigrants to the United States or Canada's 6 million francophone Quebeckers. And elsewhere? That is a heroic guess: 100 million to 1 billion is Mr. Crystal's, depending how you define "can." Let us be bold: In all, 20–25 percent of Earth's 6 billion people can use English; not the English of England, let alone of Dr. Johnson, but English.

[1]"The World Language." The Economist. Millennium Issue 31 Dec. 1999: 85.

4 That number is soaring as each year brings new pupils to school and carries off monolingual oldies—and now as the Internet spreads. And the process is self-reinforcing. As business spreads across frontiers, the company that wants to move its executives around and to promote the best of them, regardless of nationality, encourages the use of English. So the executive who wants to be in the frame or to move to another employer learns to use it. English has long dominated learned journals: German, Russian or French (depending on the field) may be useful to their expert readers, but English is essential. So, if you want your own work published—and widely read by your peers—then English is the language of choice.

5 The growth of the cinema, and still more so of television, has spread the dominant language. Foreign movies or sitcoms may be dubbed into major languages, but for smaller audiences they are usually subtitled. Result: A Dutch or Danish or even Arab family has an audiovisual learning aid in its living room, and usually the language spoken on screen is English.

6 The birth of the computer and its American operating systems gave English a nudge ahead; that of the Internet has given it a huge push. Any Web-linked household today has a library of information available at the click of a mouse. And, unlike the books on its own shelves or in the public library, maybe four-fifths is written in English. That proportion may lessen, as more non-English sites spring up. But English will surely dominate.

7 The Web of course works both ways. An American has far better access today than ever before to texts in German or Polish or Gaelic. But the average American has no great incentive to profit from it. That is not true the other way round. The Web may even save some minilanguages. But the big winner will be English.

Questions

1. Paraphrase paragraph 3, which gives several statistics about the number of people who use English. _____

2. How many reasons are given in paragraphs 4 and 5 for the spread of English throughout the world? _____ List them here. _____

3. Copy a sentence from paragraph 4 that best expresses the idea that business helps spread the use of English. Include a reporting phrase that names the source of the quoted sentence. _____

_____

_____.

4. Summarize paragraphs 5 and 6 in two or three sentences. _____

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Reading 2

This newspaper article contains support for the view that English is not destined to become the world language. It tells about a law that was considered in Brazil to prohibit the use of English in some areas of Brazilian life. The original article was divided into many short paragraphs, which is the style used in newspapers because newspaper columns are narrow. Here, paragraphs have been combined to improve the coherence.

Brazil Considers Linguistic Barricade[1]

1 In Brazil's shopping malls, the massive consumerist shrines formerly known here as *centros comerciais*, windows that used to advertise a *promoção* now trumpet "Sale." *Descontos* has become "50 percent off," and the upcoming collections that were once billed as *primavera/verão* are now touted as "spring/summer." A hairdressing salon calls itself Exuberant; a watch store is named Overtime; a restaurant goes by the name New Garden.

2 In Brazil, the largest Portuguese-speaking nation in the world, English is taking over. And Deputy Aldo Rebelo says "Basta!" "It is time to fight this disrespect of our language," says Mr. Rebelo, the author of a new bill designed to "promote and defend" the Lusitanian [Portuguese] language. "People feel humiliated and offended by having to pronounce words in a language that is not theirs. But they are obliged to, because shop owners or other people want to exhibit a false knowledge," Rebelo says. "This is the public domain; people need to buy things, to go into shopping centers, but people cannot communicate fluently because of the abuse of foreign expressions in our language."

3 Rebelo's tongue-lashing against linguistic invasion is a reaction to globalization's march. He is not alone in the defense of mother tongues. Poland recently passed a law to enforce language purity by banning foreign words from everyday transactions unless Polish translations are provided alongside. A Polish language council will catch violators, who could face stiff fines. Poland's campaign has been compared to the notorious French effort to stamp out "franglais."

4 With 178 million native speakers worldwide, Portuguese ranks seventh among most-spoken native languages after Mandarin, Hindi, Spanish, English, Arabic, and Bengali.

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[1]Downie, Andrew. "Brazil Considers Linguistic Barricade." Christian Science Monitor 6 Sep. 2000: 26 pars. 13 Sep. 2004 <http://csmonitor.com/cgi-bin/durableRedirect.pl?/durable/2000/09/06/fp7s2-csm.shtml>.

5 Rebelo's bill . . . rejects the increasing influx of English expressions and requires that Brazil's native tongue be used in business, formal, and social situations. While those strictures are laughed off by many as unenforceable—one envisions "language police" monitoring cafe chatter and the like—Rebelo's bill thunders that those not respecting Portuguese are "damaging Brazil's cultural patrimony." The linguistic outlaws would face as yet undecided punishment—perhaps classes in Portuguese, Rebelo has suggested.

6 One goal of the bill is linguistic purity among government officials, Rebelo says, citing the offenses of President Fernando Henrique Cardoso, who recently used the English expression "fast track" in a speech.

7 The bill would particularly affect the worlds of finance and commerce, where throwing up a sign in English is seen as a trendy way of grabbing potential customers' attention. According to a recent study, 93 of the 252 stores in São Paulo's Morumbi shopping center featured English words in their names. That would change under Rebelo's law. The owners of Laundromat would have to wash their hands of the name. Hot dogs would be off the menu, and personal trainers would have to find a new way to describe their services. The Banco do Brasil's "Personal Banking" would need to translate itself, and the Rock in Rio music festival would have to dance to a different tune. Children's clothing store Kid Smart would lose its exotic appeal in a country where most people do not speak English.

8 Although Rebelo recognizes that in today's fast-paced and shrinking world, words like "e-mail," "mouse," and "delete" have entered Portuguese almost overnight, he says the rush to use English words ignores the fact that in many cases perfectly good Portuguese ones already exist. "We can say *entrega a domiçilio* because everyone knows what it means, so why use the word 'delivery'?" Rebelo asks, highlighting one recent fad. "Restaurants use 'valet parking,' but why not use *maniobrista*? This law will prohibit these abuses."

9 Linguistic experts agree and point to the richness of Portuguese. Used as an official language in seven countries outside of Portugal, Portuguese boasts 24 vowel sounds, compared with five in English, and includes more than 350,000 words derived primarily from Latin, Arabic, and Iberian tribal languages.

10 Antonio Olinto, an author and member of the Brazilian Academy of Letters, says that, although it is impossible to legislate how people talk, the proposal has value because it has created a debate about the use of foreign words in Brazil. While stopping the trend is impossible, he says, Brazil can counter the linguistic invasion by adapting its language, just as it did with the word "football" (soccer), which over time became *futebol*. "Globalization exists, and I don't think there is any way of escaping it," says Mr. Olinto. "But in time, words will be adapted into Portuguese, and things will get better." Rebelo acknowledges that the desire to speak English may eventually ebb, but he called on Brazilians meanwhile to use their mother tongue whenever possible.

11 The legislator advises those tempted to utter or write foreign words to consult the style book of *O Estado de São Paulo*, one of the nation's biggest newspapers, which offers the following wordy wisdom: "(1) You have a language, Portuguese, that is just as good and as functional as any other. (2) It is your language."

12 But it's the cash register, not linguistic pride, that inspires lingerie store manager Silvana Cannone when she's looking for just the right word. "We cut the letters out ourselves, and 'Sale' is shorter than *Promoção*, so it's easier," she explains. "Nowadays, everyone knows what 'sale' means. And besides, it sounds more chic."

Questions

1. The introductory paragraph to this essay is
   a. a funnel introduction.
   b. a historical introduction.
   c. a series of examples

2. The main topic of this essay is
   a. a proposed law in Brazil banning the use of English in certain situations.
   b. the prevalence of English in Brazil.
   c. the reasons English is popular among shopkeepers and other businesses in Brazil.

3. Find the sentence that, in your opinion, best expresses the main topic and paraphrase it here. _____

4. Summarize Mr. Rebolo's reasons. _____

5. Find a paragraph that discusses other countries' opposition to English. Write a one-sentence summary of that paragraph here. _____